

Ring-tailed lemur

Lemur catta

With their distinctive black-and-white faces and long, striped tails, ring-tailed lemurs are the most recognizable of all the lemur species. Covered in thick, gray-brown fur, they move so easily both on the ground and in trees that they seem like a cross between a cat and a raccoon. In fact, ring-tailed lemurs belong to the primates—the order that includes monkeys, apes, and humans. This means that, just like humans, lemurs have fingerprints and vision is their prime sense, although smell is also important to them.

Girl power

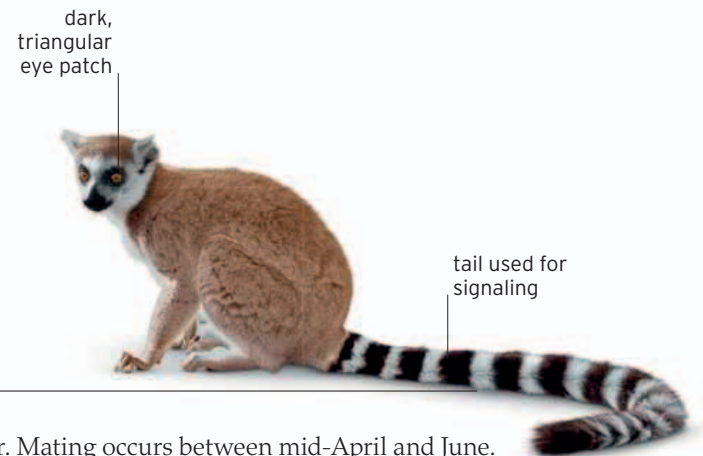
Native only to Madagascar, ring-tailed lemurs are found mainly in bush and dry forests, where these highly sociable animals live in groups of several males and females. Females rule the troop, winning fights with males, getting the best food, and ultimately deciding which males to mate with. During the mating season, males have “stink fights”—rubbing their tails over scent glands in their genitals and wrists, then flicking them at

each other. Mating occurs between mid-April and June. In August or September, females give birth to one or two babies, weighing less than 4 oz (100 g) each. Females tend to raise their young jointly, often caring for groups of infants and carrying each other's offspring.

Sunshine and socializing

Unlike most other lemurs, ring-tails sunbathe in the morning, socializing at these times with a wide range of vocalizations and facial expressions. Ringtails are mainly plant eaters, including flowers and even bark and sap, but the fruit of the tamarind tree is a favorite. Sometimes they eat insects or small vertebrates such as lizards and, rarely, birds.

The main predators of ringtails are fossas—catlike carnivores also native to Madagascar—and large birds of prey, but devastation of habitat by humans is the chief threat to these and all other lemur species. On average, ring-tails live for 16–19 years in the wild, but they have been known to survive to the age of 27 in captivity.



△ BLACK-AND-WHITE RUFFED LEMUR

Unlike ring-tails, which spend much of their time on the ground, black-and-white ruffed lemurs (*Varecia variegata*) prefer to live high up in the tree canopy.

◁ EARLY MORNING RITUAL

Ring-tailed lemurs sit upright and expose their bellies to the warmth of the sun before beginning the search for their first meal of the day.